



Perceived Vice and Unengaging Edification

Game Analyses of Two Christian Digital Games.

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*A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the
degree of M.Sc. in Digital Games.*



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To John Doe

Some more descriptive text.

Acknowledgements

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Abstract

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Contents

List of Abbreviations	x
1 Introduction	1
1.1 Motivation	1
1.2 Aims and Objectives	1
1.3 Our Approach	1
1.4 Document Structure	2
2 Background & Literature Overview	3
2.1 What Are Christian Digital Games?	3
2.1.1 Existing Definitions	4
2.1.2 My Definition	6
2.2 Related Work	9
2.3 Applicable Theories	10
2.3.1 Warrant Reduction Assumption	10
2.4 Summary	12
3 Materials & Methods	13
3.1 Summary	13
4 Analysis & Discussion	14
4.1 Summary	14
5 Conclusions	15
5.1 Revisiting the Aims and Objectives	15
5.2 Critique and Limitations	15
5.3 Future Work	16
5.4 Final Remarks	16

<i>Contents</i>	vii
Appendix A Media Content	17
Appendix B Installation Instructions	18
Appendix C User Manual	19
References	20

List of Figures

List of Tables

List of Abbreviations

Introduction

1.1 | Motivation

1.2 | Aims and Objectives

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1.3 | Our Approach

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1.4 | Document Structure

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Background & Literature Overview

2.1 | What Are Christian Digital Games?

What makes something, or even someone, “Christian”? Regardless of the subject of discussion, this question is always likely to spark conflicting views. For instance, Schultze and Woods (2008) noted that fans of U2’s Bono have questioned his Christian status after he swore during an award show. The authors further observed that Christian groups also disagree on what it means for a cultural artefact to be Christian. For example, they mention that many Evangelicals consider media as Christian only if it is made by and for Evangelicals. Others, such as Lawton (2021), MacInnis (2025), or Unthank (2023), may prefer to consider content, authorial intent, or media impact when determining whether literature, music, or film is Christian.

Similarly, games scholar Kevin Schut states that currently there is no consensus on what defines a Christian game (Faith Forms, 2024, 8:38). This becomes apparent when one examines online discussion around the topic. For example, one of the factors that Moon Channel (2023) considers when determining if a digital game is Christian is that it must promote Christian morals. Meanwhile, Hartgrove (2022) considers *Hypnospace Outlaw* (Tholen, 2019) a Christian game primarily because its creator, Jay Tholen, identifies as a Christian¹.

From the examples mentioned so far, it becomes evident that the question of what constitutes something as Christian is a highly contentious and subjective matter. Therefore, before analysing the opinions surrounding them, I needed to establish an operational definition of “Christian digital games”.

¹Although Hartgrove does discuss the game’s content somewhat, he does not deem explicit ideological content as necessary for a digital game to be Christian.

2.1.1 | Existing Definitions

Earlier work by Schut (2013) gives us a good starting point for such a definition. Based on a series of interviews with 17 Christians working in the game industry, he outlined four definitions of “Christian Games”. Explicitly Christian Games “feature Bible stories or passages, very clear presentation of the gospel message, and stories that very openly have a Christian worldview”. As an example, Schut raises *Big Bible Town* (Third Day Games, 2010), a digital game which aims to teach children about Bible stories. Meanwhile, Allegorical Christian Games “have stories that are not necessarily openly Christian but have Christian themes or messages underneath them” (p. 137). Interviewees mentioned no instances of such games, but they cited the *Narnia* series (Lewis, 1950–1956/2000) an example of this style.

Interviewees also raised what Schut terms as Evangelical Christian digital games, which “focus on sharing the gospel with people who aren't Christians”. (pp. 137–138). However, this is only a hypothetical definition since neither Schut nor his interviewees could cite any examples. Lastly, Christian-friendly games, such as *Bejeweled Deluxe* (Karpalka, 2001/2006) (Newtoy, 2009) and *Words With Friends*, are “clean and safe, without significant violence, adult sexuality, swearing, anti-Christian worldviews, and other things that Christians might find offensive or disturbing” (p. 137).

Schut's work also gives valuable insight into how the term “Christian Games” is used. For example, he notes that most of the interviewees commonly defined “Christian Games” as either Explicitly Christian Games or Allegorically Christian games. However, only few of them considered Christian-friendly games part of the genre. Although this information proved useful for my study, I was hesitant to reuse these definitions due to Schut's ambiguous use of the term “Christian”; as I have already mentioned in the beginning of this section (see Section 2.1), individuals may not necessarily agree on what determines something as Christian.

Subsequent work by Schut (2026) acknowledges the subjective application of this term (p. 310), and clarifies his use of the term “Christian”. While there are various groups which could be described as Christian, Schut observes that the Christian media industry in North America is influenced primarily by Evangelicals. He attributes their dominance to their collective focus on proselytism and their eagerness to adopt new media technologies as a means to that end. However, he also remarks that Evangelicals have not always counted for the majority of North American Christians, and that they are still garnering a presence in most other countries. Furthermore, he also

notes that other groups, such as Roman Catholics, have also produced Christian games. Consequently, he specifies that, within the context of Christian digital games, the term “Christian” is often synonymous with “Evangelical”, though this is not always the case.

Within the same study, Schut continued to investigate the ways in which Christians have employed the term “Christian” to describe digital games. He found that, occasionally, Christians have argued that digital games with Christian authorship are Christian games. However, after a brief survey of the types of digital games which Christians have described as Christian, Schut concluded that they typically use the term to disclose the presence of Christian ideology within a digital game. However, Schut does not provide a more detailed, formal definition which I could use for my research.

Around 12 years earlier, Gonzalez (2014) had already shown that the overwhelming majority of Christian digital games had Evangelical associations by compiling a comprehensive list of religious digital games. However, unlike Schut, Gonzales does not opt to define Christian games for her research. Instead, she defines “religious games” to study Evangelical digital games within the broader picture of playful religious software. Using “agential realism” as her ontological frame, Gonzales describes something as “religious” if it stages interactions between human and non-human beings (p. 24), such as angels and demons.

Based on this definition, she excludes games like *Castlevania* (Akamatsu, 1986) from her study, which include typically religious materials to embellish their fictional world. She does this because these games do not depict the non-human others as agents with which borders must be negotiated, but as imaginary entities. Similarly, she disregards games such as *Run, Jesus Run!* (Pederchini, 2010) or *Crucify-me! Jesus* (Chapman, 2000), which utilize religious material derisively, since these negotiate boundaries between human groups. Furthermore, Gonzales limits her study to religious organizations, which she defines as a long-lived alliance of human and non-human entities which jointly determine the borders of humanity.

While this definition is more rigorous than either of Schut’s definitions, my original research question does not concern games associated with religions unrelated to Christianity. Therefore, I could not use it for my research. Nevertheless, her definition of religious organisations proved useful as a source of inspiration for my own definition, which I describe in the following section.

2.1.2 | My Definition

Each of the definitions mentioned in the previous section presents valid ideas about what can qualify a game as “Christian” or “religious”. However, given that the definitions are either incomplete or cover games outside my field of study, I could not reuse them for my research. Therefore, using these existing definitions as a point of departure, I created my own definition of “Christian digital games” (or “Christian games” for short).

Due to the vague nature of the “Christian” label, which I have already discussed in the start of this section (see Section 2.1), a complete definition of Christian games also needs to elucidate its use of the term. During my research, I could not find much insight into how players or developers use the term in the context of Christian games. While I have found blogs by Oliver (2014, 2016) which mention Evangelicals when discussing Christian games, there are also other individuals which do not specify any particular denomination (Hartgrove, 2022; Monkastery, 2018; Moon Channel, 2023)². Meanwhile, related studies either fail to elaborate on their usage (Schut, 2013) or employ it as a catch-all term for various religious groups (Bernauer, 2012; Schut, 2026). Furthermore, within her list of religious games, Gonzalez (2014) seems to use “Christian” as an overarching category for games associated with Christianity.

Therefore, to facilitate discussion of existing research, I defined “Christianity” as a blanket term encompassing a constellation of long-lived groups or institutions that promote their interpretations of Christ’s teachings, such as Evangelicals, Presbyterians, Anglicans, Roman Catholics, Greek Orthodox, and Mormons. Similarly, something (e.g. an ideology or belief) or someone is “Christian” when it is primarily based on, or actively aims to observe the teachings of Jesus Christ as understood by one or more of these communities. Of course, these definitions are by no means authoritative; they only serve to establish a common understanding for discussion.

After establishing a working definition of “Christian”, I proceeded by defining Christian games as a genre. I considered defining Christian games as digital games with Christian authorship as suggested by Hartgrove (2022). However, doing so would also include several games which have no significantly religious content. Take Hartgrove’s example for instance. He argues that through its aesthetically pleasing qualities, artistic excellence, and believable characters, *Hypnospace Outlaw* (Tholen, 2019) reveals Tholen’s

²Nevertheless, it is worth noting that the examples cited within these discussions are Evangelical games.

love for beauty originating from his Christian beliefs. While this philosophy can be connected to Christianity, it is hardly exclusive to it. Therefore, based on its content, players may just as easily consider the game as secular.

Based on the remarks by Unthank (2023) on Christian films, I could have chosen to define Christian games based on authorial intent. After all, many Christian games are created with the intent to educate their players about Christianity (Gonzalez, 2014, p. 60; Schut, 2026, pp. 303, 306), so it would have been simple to define Christian games as digital games created with such a purpose. Nevertheless, players have widely acclaimed games outside this category and rarely label them as preachy, in spite of their Christian content³. Therefore, by doing so I would have excluded games of interest to this study.

Furthermore, I explored the possibility of defining Christian games based on the impact a game has on its developers and players, but this was difficult to measure for any given game. Hence, though MacInnis (2025) describes Christian music as music which makes its performers and listeners more willing to love their God and neighbour, I shall not be imitating such efforts for digital games.

Given that I was investigating players' perceptions of Christian digital games, I based my definition on the most common uses of the term, which relate to Christian ideology (Schut, 2026). Other elements, such as biblical stories, Bible quotes, Christian themes and messages, which Schut (2013) outlines in his definitions of Explicitly Christian games and Allegorical Christian games, could be said to be manifestations of such a worldview. Additionally, Gonzalez (2014) remarks that many Evangelical games betray a theology of spiritual warfare prevalent among Evangelicals in the 1980s and 90s, even if ideology is not a prerequisite in her definition of religious games.

Therefore, for this study, “Christian games” are digital games with an underlying Christian worldview that presents itself through legible signifiers. That is, the game contains elements which players can trace to Christian ideology with relative ease.

Obvious examples of such signifiers include adaptations of Bible stories and the

³Throughout my research I found four such games: *That Dragon, Cancer* (Numinous Games, 2016a), *In His Time* (yona, 2023), *and Roger* (yona, 2025), and *Dropsy* (Tholen, 2015). At the time of writing, all four have Steam pages with a rating of over 80% (Numinous Games, 2016b; TearyHand Studio, 2023, 2025; Tendershoot, 2015).

inclusion of Bible quotes, such as in *Super 3-D Noah's Ark* (Wisdom Tree, 1994/2014). Other Christian games indicate their Christian status through their treatment of their scripted narrative's themes. Consider *That Dragon, Cancer* (Numinous Games, 2016a) for example. Its scripted narrative tackles the loss of the developers' son through the lens of their Christian faith, making their spirituality explicit in the process.

Alternatively, scripted narratives in Christian games can feature thinly veiled Christian allegories. The developers of *Alum* (Orsie, 2015), describe it as “a sort of Christian Allegory along the lines of Pilgrims [sic] Progress or The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe” (Crashable Studios, 2015). Some players recognised this, calling *Alum* a Christian game, often citing, or implying, its narrative as their primary reason⁴. One player specifies that they classify it as a Christian game because the game's scripted narrative develops a loving relationship between the eponymous player character, “Alum”, and a deity called the “Unfeigned Altruist”, while also pitting Alum in a fight against dark forces⁵ (thomascanarias, 2016). Even if players do not notice the parallels to Christianity while playing, the game's ending makes one parallel explicit when it calls Jesus Christ “the true and living Unfeigned Altruist”.

For the most part, *Alum* attempts to be more covert than *Super 3-D Noah's Ark* (Wisdom Tree, 1994/2014) or *That Dragon, Cancer* (Numinous Games, 2016a) about its ties to Christianity. Nevertheless, all three narrow the range of possible associations such that even players with a cursory knowledge of Christianity can make the connection. The same cannot be said about the example raised by Hartgrove (2022); players may just as easily relate the appreciation towards beauty evident within *Hypnospace Outlaw* (Tholen, 2019) to a non-religious worldview.

Since my definition requires the digital game in question to be aligned with Christian ideology, I did not consider games which draw on Christianity for inspiration. So, despite requiring players to journey through hell and slaughter demon hordes, *Doom* (id Software, 1993) falls outside of the field being studied. The same cannot be said for games which reference Christianity to mock it or its followers. As an example, Gonzalez (2014, p. 120) mentions BoMToons, a Mormon game developer which created multiple digital games poking fun at Mormon scripture and culture. However, the examples brought up by players when criticising Christian games, such as *Left Behind: Eternal Forces* (Inspired Media Entertainment, 2006) and *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness* (En-

⁴For examples, see Arkane (2015), hamja (2015) and virotti (2017).

⁵See Chapter 4 for a more detailed analysis of *Alum*'s narrative.

gelbrite, 1994)⁶, tend to be more earnest about their subject matter. Hence, I limited my study to digital games which approach Christianity in a more solemn manner.

2.2 | Related Work

With my area of study established, I am now in a position to discuss related research examining mainstream reception of Christian games. As I will demonstrate shortly, this study aims to address an existing research gap by examining the content of Christian games as a potential cause of players' critiques.

Apart from providing four distinct definitions for Christian games (see Section 2.1.1), Schut (2013) also relays the opinions of the interviewees regarding this genre. Some of the developers interviewed did mention that they consider Christian games as preachy (pp. 136, 139), but Schut does not attempt to learn if there are any reasons behind this verdict.

Throughout my research, I was unable to find another study analysing the opinions surrounding Christian games. Gonzalez (2014) briefly mentions bloggers of unnoticed games mocking Christian games (p. 8), and claims of unoriginality (pp. 143–144), an issue closely related to the one under examination. However, her dissertation mostly avoids discussing the enjoyment derived from Christian games. When reflecting on her own experiences playing Evangelical games, she recalls occasions of bewilderment only to dismiss them. Instead, she asserts that she found Evangelical games to be “wonderful, unforgettably good games” (p. 266). Nevertheless, these moments of discomfort may merit further attention; understanding their cause might help clarify the reasons behind certain player's dismay, and help future developers to avoid these pitfalls. While it may be tempting to dismiss all criticism as snide remarks, it is beneficial to give an honest consideration to negative feedback. This is doubly true when that feedback comes from one's intended target audience.

Although neither Bernauer (2012) nor Schut (2026) mention the negative opinions surrounding Christian games, both propose reasons for their lack of success. For one, Bernauer maintains that the lack of mainstream interest in Christian games is, in part, due to the explicit Christian convictions presented within these games. Furthermore, she also blames Christian games' (mostly) young target audience, noting that studies found the average gamer to be around thirty-five years old. Lastly, she presents several

⁶These examples were mentioned by Hartgrove (2022) and Moon Channel (2023) respectively.

issues stemming from a lack of finances when comparing Christian game companies to other studios. These include their inability to publish their games on consoles, the lack of both local and online multiplayer in most of their titles, and the short lifespan of these firms.

Meanwhile, Schut attributes three reasons for the lack of commercial success of Christian games within Evangelical circles. Primarily, he ascribes this predicament to the lack of blockbusters within the Christian games industry; unlike Christian television, for instance, Christian games do not have their own *VeggieTales* (Vischer, 1993–2015) to drive sales. He also notes that “the legacy of moral panics over *Dungeons and Dragons* in the 1980s predisposed many Evangelicals to be skeptical of video games” (p. 302). Additionally, he cites an argument by Moon Channel (2023) regarding the Protestant work ethic within America, which conflicts with thriftless, unproductive play. However, Schut admits that Evangelical’s receptiveness towards consumerism discredits this explanation somewhat.

Although all of these reasons may indeed contribute to the unpopularity of Christian games, most of them are factors external to the games’ development process. Bernauer offers actionable suggestions for some of the issues raised, such as targeting older age demographics and making Christian content more implicit. However, most of the reasons given by both researchers are difficult or even impossible for Christian game developers to control. Furthermore, both of them also fail to acknowledge the main reason why many players have decried Christian games in the first place — the games’ content.

Hence, in Chapter 4 I examine two Christian games in the hopes of better understanding what causes certain players to view Christian games as preachy. In the following section, I shall now look at some existing theories which could help explain didacticism in Christian games.

2.3 | Applicable Theories

2.3.1 | Warrant Reduction Assumption

In his article, Repp (2012) describes what he calls the “warrant reduction assumption”. He offers this as an explanation of why literary works, primarily those outside academic contexts, may be considered didactic. In his explanation, he makes two assumptions clear. Firstly, he presupposes that authors can convey their accounts to readers without necessarily inserting themselves as narrators or characters within the text. Secondly, he

presumes that one's writing may convey aspects of their intellectual character. Inspired, by Aristotle's model of moral nature, he proposes that noetic vice can be thought of as gradually ingrained dispositions, which hinder one's enlightenment.

Repp proposes two definitions to explain his theory. "Testimonial beliefs" describe the convictions formed from someone else's accounts, whereas the "warrant" describes the premise on which one believes a source to be trustworthy. He argues that, when authors are overly overt, readers may be given reason to believe that the author might possess some intellectual vice such as zealotry, prejudice, or arrogance. As a result, their warrant for the writer's testimonial beliefs are reduced, since they believe that information being presented is compromised. He likens this phenomenon to when someone is said to "protest too much". In other words, when they argue a point so frequently or emphatically that they raise one's suspicion on the truth of their statements.

Though Repp proposes this theory primarily in relation to literary works, one can see through examples that it also can also apply for Christian games. Take the review by Arkane (2015) for *Alum* (Orsie, 2015), a Christian game which I will be analysing in more detail in Chapter 4. He pans the game for its heavy-handedness, which he blames on the dogmatism of the game's developers:

I hope the team that worked on this will expand a little bit, bring in some people with different perspectives. Maybe have someone there whose only job is to say, "Hey, that story element you just wrote? Maybe we should find a more subtle approach to implementing it." I'm not saying, "Don't make a religious game." I'm saying don't get caught in an echo chamber of religious ideas and lose sight of the 'game' aspects of it. (para. 5)

The review stands as the most helpful review on the game's Steam page, with 189 users having marked it is helpful as of the time of writing. Though not all of them might share the exact same opinion of Arkane, it is reasonable to assume that his points resonated with some of them. Meanwhile Hartgrove (2022) calls *Left Behind: Eternal Forces* (Inspired Media Entertainment, 2006) "propaganda" (para. 13) due to its focus on identity politics of conservative American Christians and creationist preachings. Censorious Idler (2018) produces very similar critiques about fundamentalism in *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness*, the other game under analysis in Chapter 4, deeming it "unabashedly preachy" (A Third Way section, para. 8).

2.4 | Summary

Materials & Methods

This section should include a recipe of what you did (explain what you have done so if someone wants to reproduce the experiment, they can). Should also include a description of statistical methods used (if any).¹

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3.1 | Summary

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¹For more information see: <http://rc.rcjournal.com/content/49/10/1229.short>. Last Accessed: 27th November, 2024.

Analysis & Discussion

Should include a reiteration of the experiments, and their outcome. Together with a description (discussion). Preamble should include a reminder of the aims and objectives together with a list of experiments to achieve these. Should include many charts and other visualization with appropriate descriptions.¹

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4.1 | Summary

¹Another footnote example.

Conclusions

This section should have a summary of the whole project. The original aims and objective and whether these have been met should be discussed. It should include a section with a critique and a list of limitations of your proposed solutions. Future work should be described, and this should not be marginal or silly (e.g. add machine learning models). It is always good to end on a positive note (i.e. 'Final Remarks').

5.1 | Revisiting the Aims and Objectives

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5.2 | Critique and Limitations

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5.3 | Future Work

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5.4 | Final Remarks

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Media Content

If the dissertation has a DVD or pendrive attached to it, you will need a section which explains what is on the media (structure, files, data, etc.). This could be a table with filename and description.

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Installation Instructions

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User Manual

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